

City Routes

Shanghai → Suzhou →

Hangzhou: Poetic Cities &

Water Towns (5-6 Days)

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Shanghai → Suzhou → Hangzhou: Poetic Cities & Water Towns (5-6 Days)

This 5-6 day route traces the most culturally refined corridor in China -- the Jiangnan (江南, "south of the Yangtze") region that has inspired poets, painters, and emperors for 2,000 years. From Shanghai's futuristic skyline to Suzhou's classical gardens and Hangzhou's West Lake, this is China at its most elegant. All three cities are connected by HSR in under 1.5 hours.

Day 1-2: Shanghai -- Where East Meets West

Day 1 Morning: The Bund (外滩)

Start at Shanghai's most iconic waterfront -- a 1.5 km promenade of 52 heritage

buildings representing Art Deco, Baroque, and Neoclassical architecture, facing Pudong's futuristic skyline across the Huangpu River. Best visited at sunrise (6 AM, no crowds) or after dark when the skyline is illuminated. Walk south from the old HSBC building to the Former French Concession for a journey through 150 years of Shanghai history.

24/7 (outdoor) | Free

Day 1 Afternoon: Yu Garden (豫园) & French Concession

Walk south from the Bund (15 min) to Yu Garden -- a 400-year-old classical Chinese garden with rockeries, koi ponds, and pavilions. The surrounding bazaar (豫园商城) has traditional tea houses and the famous Nanxiang steamed buns (南翔馒头店). Then take Metro Line 10 to the Former French Concession (法租界) -- walk along Wukang Road (武康路) for Instagram-worthy shots of the iconic Wukang Mansion (武康大楼, 1924),

tree-lined streets, Art Deco architecture, and independent cafes.

豫园 09:00-16:45 | ¥40

Day 2: Tianzifang (田子坊) & Nanjing Road (南京路步行街)

Tianzifang is a labyrinth of art galleries, craft shops, and tiny bars squeezed into renovated shikumen (石库门) lane houses -- Shanghai's unique architectural fusion of Western and Chinese styles. Then head to Nanjing Road (南京路步行街), China's most famous shopping boulevard -- 1.2 km of neon-lit stores stretching from People's Square to the Bund. Take the little tourist train (¥5) for a fun ride down the pedestrian street.

10:00-22:00 (Tianzifang) | Free (entry)

Day 3: HSR to Suzhou -- Gardens & Silk

Getting There: HSR Shanghai → Suzhou

The Shanghai-Suzhou HSR takes just 25-30 minutes. Second class: ¥39.5. Trains depart every 10-15 minutes from Shanghai Hongqiao Station (上海虹桥站) or Shanghai Station (上海站). This is one of the most frequent HSR services in the world -- you can literally show up and buy a ticket for the next train.

Day 3 Morning: Humble Administrator's Garden (拙政园)

The largest and most famous of Suzhou's 69 classical gardens -- a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1997. Built in 1509, the garden covers 5.2 hectares of ponds, pavilions, bamboo groves, and covered walkways designed to frame views like living Chinese landscape paintings. The "36 Mandarin Duck Hall" (三十六鸳鸯馆) with its blue glass windows is particularly stunning. Allow 2-3 hours.

Tip:

Arrive at opening (7:30 AM) to beat the tour groups.

07:30-17:30 (Mar-Nov) / 07:30-17:00 (Dec-Feb) | ¥70 (Apr-Oct) / ¥50 (Nov-Mar) | ! Book

online in advance

Day 3 Afternoon: Pingjiang Road (平江路) & Tiger Hill (虎丘)

Pingjiang Road is Suzhou's best-preserved historic canal street -- an 800m cobblestone lane running alongside a narrow canal, lined with whitewashed houses, teahouses, and silk shops. Take a traditional boat ride (¥50/person, 30 min) along the canal. Then take a taxi (¥15) to Tiger Hill (虎丘) -- the "leaning tower of Suzhou" (云岩寺塔), a 47m pagoda that has been leaning for over 1,000 years, predating Pisa's tower by 400 years. Su Shi, the Song Dynasty poet, said: "It is a lifelong pity if having been to Suzhou you did not visit Tiger Hill."

平江路全天 / 虎丘 07:30-18:00 | 平江路免费 / 虎丘 ¥60

Suzhou Silk (苏州丝绸)

Suzhou has been China's silk capital for 2,000 years. Visit the Suzhou Silk Museum

(苏州丝绸博物馆) near the North Temple Pagoda to see the entire silk-making process --

from silkworm cocoons to shimmering fabrics. The gift shop has excellent silk scarves

(¥100-500) and quilts (¥800-3,000) that make perfect souvenirs.

09:00-17:00 (Tue-Sun) | Free

Day 4: Water Town Day Trip -- Tongli (同里) or Zhouzhuang (周庄)

Tongli Water Town (同里古镇)

A 1,000-year-old water town 18 km southeast of Suzhou -- less commercialized than

Zhouzhuang and more intimate. The town is built on a network of canals connected by

49 stone bridges. Highlights include the Retreat & Reflection Garden (退思园, a UNESCO

World Heritage Site), the Three Bridges loop (三桥 -- locals believe walking across all three brings good luck), and the evening lantern-lit canal reflections. Take bus 725 from Suzhou's South Bus Station (苏州汽车南站, 40 min, ¥5) or taxi (¥60-80).

07:30-21:00 | ¥100 (联票含退思园等景点) | 摇橹船 ¥120/船 (可坐6人)

Alternative: Zhouzhuang Water Town (周庄古镇)

China's most famous water town -- more touristy but undeniably beautiful, especially at dawn before the crowds arrive. The twin bridges (双桥) are the most photographed scene in Chinese water town culture. Take a bus from Suzhou's North Bus Station (苏州汽车北站, 1.5 hours, ¥15). Zhouzhuang is best visited on weekdays to avoid massive weekend crowds.

07:30-21:00 | ¥100 | ! Weekends extremely crowded -- go on a weekday

Day 5-6: Hangzhou -- Paradise on Earth

Getting There: HSR Suzhou → Hangzhou

The HSR takes approximately 1.5 hours. Second class: ¥75. Trains depart frequently from Suzhou Station or Suzhou North Station. Arrive at Hangzhou East Station (杭州东站), which connects to Metro Lines 1 and 4.

Day 5: West Lake Boat Ride (西湖游船)

West Lake (西湖) is China's most celebrated lake -- a UNESCO World Heritage Site that has inspired Chinese art for over 1,000 years. Rent a rowing boat (手划船, ¥150/hour for the whole boat, fits 4-6 people) or take the painted pleasure boat (画舫, ¥55/person) to the island with the famous Three Pools Mirroring the Moon (三潭印月) -- the scene on the back of the ¥1 bill. Walk the Su Causeway (苏堤) and Bai Causeway (白堤), both lined with willow trees and peach blossoms (spectacular in spring). The "Broken Bridge" (断桥) at

the north end is where the Legend of the White Snake begins.

24/7 (outdoor) | Free (lake) | 手划船 ¥150/h / 画舫 ¥55/人

Day 5 Afternoon: Lingyin Temple (灵隐寺)

One of China's largest and most revered Buddhist temples, founded in 328 AD, nestled in forested hills west of West Lake. The Feilai Feng (飞来峰) grottoes outside the temple entrance contain 470 stone Buddhist carvings dating from the 10th to 14th centuries -- the most impressive collection in southeastern China. The main hall's 24.8m-tall camphor wood Buddha statue is awe-inspiring. Allow 2-3 hours.

07:00-18:00 | ¥75 (飞来峰) + ¥30 (灵隐寺) = ¥105 total

Day 6 Morning: Longjing Tea Village (龙井村)

Hangzhou is the birthplace of Longjing (Dragon Well) green tea -- China's most famous

and expensive green tea. Visit Longjing Village (龙井村), just 15 minutes southwest of West Lake, where terraced tea plantations cover the hillsides. Walk through the fields, visit a tea farmer's house, and participate in a tea-picking experience (¥50-100, seasonal). The best tea (明前龙井, pre-Qingming Dragon Well, harvested in early April) sells for ¥2,000-10,000/kg. Even a small tin (100g, ¥200-500) makes an unforgettable souvenir. Try

Longjing No. 29 Restaurant (龙井草堂)

for a tea-infused meal in a farmhouse setting.

全天 | 茶园免费 / 品茶 ¥30-100 / 采茶体验 ¥50-100

Day 6 Afternoon: Hefang Street (河坊街)

Hangzhou's most famous pedestrian street -- a restored Qing Dynasty commercial street with traditional medicine shops, tea houses, and snack stalls. Watch craftspeople

making traditional fans (王星记扇子), scissors (张小泉剪刀), and silk. Try Hangzhou specialties: 西湖醋鱼 (West Lake vinegar fish, ¥68-98), 东坡肉 (Dongpo braised pork, ¥48-68), and 龙井虾仁 (Longjing tea shrimp, ¥88-128) -- all served at nearby Zhiweiguan (知味观), Hangzhou's most famous traditional restaurant.

全天 / 店铺 10:00-22:00 | ¥50-100/人 小吃

Route Tips

* HSR Booking:

* All three cities are connected by ultra-frequent HSR services. Shanghai-Suzhou runs every 10-15 minutes -- no advance booking needed. Suzhou-Hangzhou every 20-30 minutes. Use the 12306 app.

* Best Seasons:

* Spring (March-May) for peach blossoms at West Lake and garden flowers. Autumn

(September-November) for golden ginkgo and clear skies. Summer is hot and humid (35 degC+). Avoid Golden Week (Oct 1-7).

* Budget Estimate:

* ¥4,000-7,000 per person for 6 days (mid-range). HSR tickets total: ~¥165. Gardens & attractions: ¥500-800. Hotels: ¥300-600/night. Meals: ¥80-150/day.

* Water Towns:

* Tongli is more authentic, Zhouzhuang is more famous. Visit on weekdays if possible -- weekends bring massive crowds. Both are within 1.5 hours of Suzhou by bus.

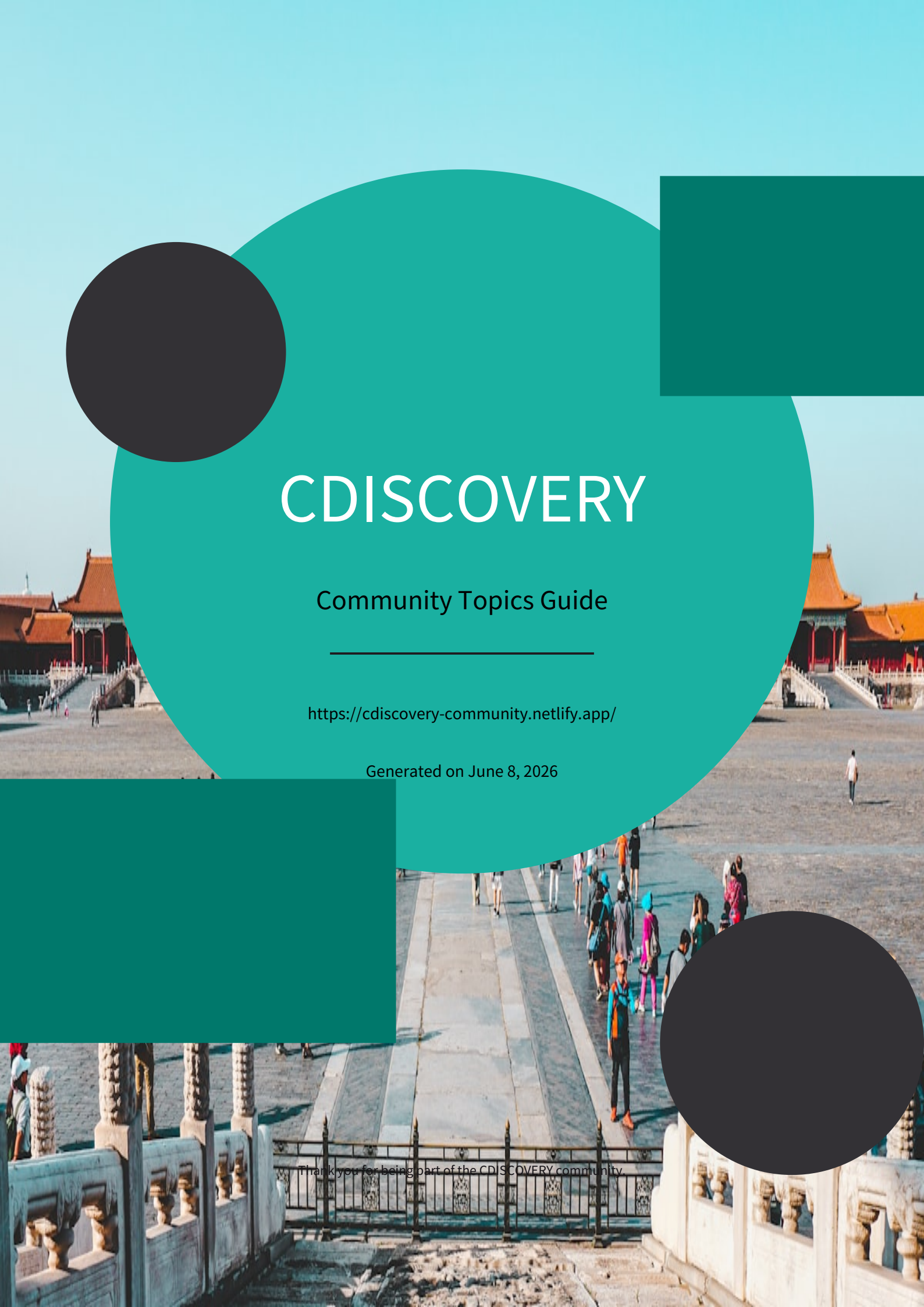
* Tea Season:

* The best Longjing tea is picked in early April (明前茶). If visiting in spring, the tea-picking experience is magical. Buy tea directly from farmers for the best quality and price.

* Essential Apps:

* 12306 (train booking), 高德地图 (navigation), DiDi (ride-hailing), 美团 (food delivery & deals), WeChat Pay / Alipay (payments).

Sources: Sources: [12306 Official Railway](https://www.12306.cn) • [UNESCO: Classical Gardens of Suzhou](https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/813) • [UNESCO: West Lake Cultural Landscape](https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/1334) • [Travel China Guide](https://www.travelchinaguide.com)



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